

Enderton's Elements of Set Theory

Malcolm

Started 1st May 2026

Contents

1	Axioms and Operations	2
1.1	First Axioms	2
1.1.1	Definitions	4
1.1.2	Subset axioms	6
1.1.3	Russell's Paradox	7
1.1.4		8

Chapter 1

Axioms and Operations

1.1 First Axioms

Extensionality axiom

If two sets have the exact same members, then they are equal:

$$\forall A \forall B [\forall x (x \in A \leftrightarrow x \in B) \rightarrow A = B]$$

(The nested implication is not an equivalence because the other direction is already true. Declaring it would be redundant.)

Empty set axiom

There is a set having no members:

$$\exists B \forall x (x \notin B)$$

Pairing axiom

For any sets u and v , there is a set having as members just u and v :

$$\forall u \forall v \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x = u \text{ or } x = v)$$

Union axiom, Preliminary form

For any sets a and b , there is a set whose members are those sets belonging either to a or to b (or both):

$$\forall a \forall b \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in a \text{ or } x \in b)$$

(next page)

Power set axiom

For any set a , there is a set whose members are exactly the subsets of a :

$$\forall a \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \subseteq a)$$

We can rewrite $x \subseteq a$ in terms of the definition of $\subseteq$:

$$\forall t (t \in x \rightarrow t \in a)$$

This list will be further expanded later to include

- Subset axioms
- Replacement axioms
- Infinity axiom
- Regularity axiom
- Choice axiom

The union axiom will be also be restated in a stronger form.

1.1.1 Definitions

Definition 1.1. $\emptyset$ is the set having no members.

This definition bestows the name “ $\emptyset$ ” on a certain set. When we write down such a definition we must be sure of two things: that there exists such a set and that there cannot be more than one set having no members. The empty set axiom provides the first fact and extensionality provides the second. Without both facts the symbol “ $\emptyset$ ” would not be well defined.

Definition 1.2.

- For any sets u and v , the **pair set** $\{u, v\}$ is the set whose members are u and v .
- For any sets a and b , the **union** $a \cup b$ is the set whose members are those sets belonging either to a or to b (or both).
- For any set a , the **power set** $\mathcal{P}a$ is the set whose members are exactly the subsets of a .

The existence and uniqueness proofs guaranteeing all of these definitions can be proved using the empty set axiom, the pairing axiom, the union axiom, and the power set axiom respectively, each in combination with the extensionality axiom.

We can use the pairing and union together to form other finite sets. Given any x we can denote the pair set $\{x, x\}$ as the *singleton* $\{x\}$ (since the pair exists and is unique). For any given x_1, x_2, x_3 we can define

$$\{x_1, x_2, x_3\} = \{x_1, x_2\} \cup \{x_3\}$$

(since the union exists and is unique for any two particular sets). Similarly we can define $\{x_1, x_2, x_3, x_4\}$ and so forth.
(next page)

Notation

Our existence axioms have been of the form “there exists a set B whose members are those sets x satisfying the condition $--$ ”

$$\exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --)$$

Where if some other sets $t_1, \dots, t_k$ are involved in the condition, then the full version becomes

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --)$$

With the blank filled in by some expression involving $t_1, \dots, t_k$ and x . The empty set axiom can be written as

$$\exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \neq x)$$

Now let us be more general and consider any statement of the form

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --)$$

If the statement were true, then the set B , by the statement itself, as well as by equivalence, can be named by use of the abstraction notation:

$$B = \{x \mid --\}$$

*My interpretation was that showing the existence and uniqueness of B amounts to showing:

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k [\exists B (\forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow --) \wedge \forall B' (\forall x (x \in B' \leftrightarrow --) \rightarrow B' = B))]$$

The sets defined earlier can similarly be named in this notation:

$$\begin{aligned}\emptyset &= \{x \mid x \neq x\} \\ \{u, v\} &= \{x \mid x = u \text{ or } x = v\} \\ a \cup b &= \{x \mid x \in a \text{ or } x \in b\} \\ \mathcal{P}a &= \{x \mid x \subseteq a\}\end{aligned}$$

Note that it is not the case that all statements of the general form are true. For instance

$$\exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x = x)$$

is false as it asserts the existence of a set B to which every set belongs.

1.1.2 Subset axioms

Subset axioms

For each formula $--$ not containing B , the following is an axiom:

$$\forall t_1 \dots \forall t_k \forall c \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in c \wedge --)$$

Given an existing set c , this axiom asserts the existence of a set whose members are exactly those sets in c such that $--$.

See that such a set must be the subset of an existing set c (thus the name). The set can be named by use of a variation on the abstraction notation:

$$B = \{x \in c \mid --\}$$

Intersection

One of the subset axioms is

$$\forall a \forall c \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in c \wedge x \in a)$$

The axiom asserts the existence of the set we define to be the *intersection* $c \cap a$ of c and a .

Relative component

We also have as a subset axiom

$$\forall A \forall B \exists S \forall x (x \in S \leftrightarrow x \in A \wedge x \notin B)$$

This set S is the *relative component* of B in A , denoted $A - B$.

1.1.3 Russell's Paradox

Theorem 1.3. *There is no set to which every set belongs.*

Proof. Suppose, for contradiction, that there exists a set A to which every set belongs. By the subset axiom we can assert

$$\forall A \exists B \forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in A \wedge x \notin x)$$

That is, the existence of

$$B = \{x \in A \mid x \notin x\}$$

By construction of B we have

$$\forall x (x \in B \leftrightarrow x \in A \wedge x \notin x)$$

and

$$B \in B \leftrightarrow B \in A \wedge B \notin B$$

We know that $B \in A$. This can be used to show

$$B \in B \leftrightarrow B \notin B \quad \square$$

The idea here is that if B were not a member of itself, then by definition B should be in B . But if B were a member of itself, then by definition it should not be a member of itself.

1.1.4